Women in the top administrative posts of Indian higher education

Summary

- **Women rarely lead Indian higher-education institutions.** A 2025 survey of 1,352 institutions found 152 (11.24%) headed by women, up from 9.56% in 2021. For Institutes of National Importance (INIs) it found 14 of 164 (about 8.5%); none of the IITs, 2 of the IIMs and 1 of the 15 AIIMS.
- **The pool is bigger than the posts.** Women are 31.3% of professors in India (AISHE 2023-24) and 17.5% of professors at INIs, but only about 8.5% of INI heads (different bases; see Limits). The top posts are filled from professors, so the shortfall continues beyond the faculty stage.

1. What the sources say

Group	Finding
All higher-education institutions	152 of 1,352 headed by women (11.24%); 9.56% in 2021
By type	Central universities up to 14.04%; deemed 13.76%; state public 13.2%
Institutes of National Importance	14 of 164 headed by women (about 8.5%, our calculation)
IITs	None headed by a woman. The IIT system's own list of 23 directors shows no woman's name (a reading by name, undated)
IIMs / AIIMS	2 IIMs led by women / 1 of 15 AIIMS
Vice-chancellors, all universities	13 of 725 universities have had a woman vice-chancellor (the article prints 0.024%; the figure is about 1.8%). Six of the 13 are women-only universities

3. What we could not find

- **IISERs and IISc.** Our search found no record of a woman director at IISc or at any IISER, but we could not confirm this from an official list.

- **An official national count.** The Ministry does not publish the number of women heading INIs, IITs, NITs or universities. AISHE counts teachers, not heads.
- **Below the director.** Deans, registrars, heads of department and council members.

4. Limits

- The 2025 figures come from a recruitment firm's survey reported in the press; we have not seen the original report, its date of collection, or its definition of INI.
- The comparison of 31.3% of professors, 17.5% of INI professors and 8.5% of INI heads uses different years, bases and definitions. It shows direction, not a precise gap.
- Named examples were checked against the institutions' pages or press reports, not official lists, and some may have changed since.

Sources

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- AIIMS Rishikesh, "Present Director": aiimsrishikesh.edu.in
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